

Skills Summary

Seeing Small Numbers Without Counting

Use this reference while completing your worksheet or when studying.

Skill 1 — Knowing the Dot Patterns

Rule: Some arrangements are pictures of a number: a pair is 2, a triangle is 3, a square is 4, and the die's X is 5. When you know the pattern, you know the number *without counting*.

Example: A card shows dots in a square arrangement — one dot at each corner. How many?

Step 1. Name the arrangement first: a square of dots is the picture of four.

Step 2. One dot per corner of a square — the card shows 4.

Try it: A card shows four corner dots *plus* one dot in the middle — the die pattern. How many?

check: 5

Skill 2 — Seeing the Parts in a Pattern

Rule: A new pattern is easier when you spot **small parts** you already know, then put the parts together.

Example: A domino shows a triangle of dots on one half and a pair on the other. How many in all?

Step 1. Spot the two known parts: the triangle is 3 and the pair is 2.

Step 2. Put the parts together: $3 + 2 = 5$.

Try it: A card shows a triangle of dots and one extra dot. How many in all?

check: 4

(!) Watch out: If you find yourself touching every dot, pause and look for a part you know first. Counting one by one is the backup plan, not the goal here.

Skill 3 — Five-Frame Flash

Rule: A five-frame has exactly 5 boxes. A **full frame is 5**, and each **empty box** means one less than 5.

Example: A five-frame has 1 empty box. How many dots?

Step 1. Use the frame, not a count: every empty box takes one away from five.

Step 2. $5 - 1 = 4$ — the frame shows four at a glance.

Try it: A five-frame has 2 empty boxes. How many dots?

check: 3